

Fix: Language switch belongs in the header, not the menu

Type: Fix

Status: verified

Branch: `fix/language-switch-belongs-in-the-header-not-the-menu`

The problem

On a phone the language switch is inside the mobile menu. Tapping it changes the language, which navigates, which closes the menu. You are left on the page you started on and have to open the menu again to carry on.

Reported from the preview: *"when I hit Spanish in the mobile menu it takes me away from there, and I have to click the mobile menu again."*

The panel is not closing by mistake. Nothing tells it to. It closes because the `/` to `/es` hop is a real page load and the panel's open state lives in memory. There is no bug in `MobileNav` to repair.

The actual mistake is placement. Every other item in that menu is a destination; the switch is a setting that changes the whole site. Filing it with the nav links is what makes it behave in a way that feels broken.

Why the header is the right home for it

Beyond tidiness, there is a reason specific to this project. `project-plan.md` section 2 describes the Spanish-speaking client who searches in Spanish and finds nothing local. When she lands on the English page, **Español visible in the header is the instant signal that this artist speaks her language.** Behind a burger, she has to go looking for the one thing that separates Dani from every other nail tech in Calgary.

It also removes the reported problem rather than patching it. No menu, no menu state to lose.

The fix

Show the switch in the header at every width, and take it out of the mobile panel.

| | Now | After | |---|---|---| | Desktop header ($\geq 900\text{px}$) | `Español` | unchanged | | Phone header ($< 900\text{px}$) | wordmark + burger | wordmark + `Español` + burger | | Mobile panel | `Español` at the bottom | removed |

Today the switch sits inside the header's `hidden ... min-[900px]:flex` group alongside the CTA, so it disappears below 900px. It needs to come out of that group and sit as its own always-visible item; the CTA stays desktop-only.

Must not break:

- The switch's behaviour. It still swaps language on the current page and still returns to the same page. The full page load across `/` and `/es` stays - that is the root rewrite, unrelated, and now invisible because there is no menu state to lose.
- Header layout at 375px. The wordmark is roughly 60px and the burger 36px on a 375px bar, so there is room, but it needs checking rather than assuming.
- Tap target size. The switch becomes a primary phone control, not a footnote at the bottom of a menu.
- One control in one place. `ai-interaction.md` already says nothing appears twice, and two switches would be exactly that.

Build steps

- ☒ **1. Move the switch out of the panel and into the header at all widths**

`components/shell/SiteHeader.tsx` : lift `LanguageSwitch` out of the `min-[900px]:flex` group so it renders at every width. Leave the CTA in that group.

`components/shell/MobileNav.tsx` : remove the `LanguageSwitch` render and its import. Nothing else in that file changes - the panel keeps Escape, focus return, scroll lock and close-on-link.

`components/shell/LanguageSwitch.tsx` should not need changing beyond whatever sizing the header needs.

Done when: `npm run lint` and `npm run build` exit 0; the built HTML for each locale contains **exactly one** language-switch anchor, not two; and at 375px the header shows wordmark, `Español` and the burger on one line with no wrap or overlap.

Verify

At 375px on the deployed preview:

1. `Español` is visible in the header without opening the menu. 2. Tapping it goes to `/es`, and the header then reads `English`. 3. Open the menu. There is no language switch inside it. 4. The menu still opens, closes on Escape, and returns focus to the burger.

At 1280px the header is unchanged: wordmark, nav, `Español`, `Book now`.

Regression worth one look: the header is the element the mobile panel used to be trapped inside. Confirm the panel still covers the full screen after this layout change, since that bug lived in this exact component.

Verification performed

`npm run lint` exit 0, `npm run build` exit 0.

From the built output:

| Check | Result | |---|---| | Switch anchors per page | `en.html 1`, `es.html 1` - not two | | Burger per page | `en.html 1`, `es.html 1` | | Switch classes | no `hidden`, no `min-[900px]` - renders at every width | | CTA classes | still `hidden ... min-[900px]:inline-block` - desktop only |

Layout at 375px, measured by rebuilding the header's right-hand group on the live page and reading the geometry:

| | | |---|---| | wordmark | x 20 -> 76 | | `Español` | x 270 -> 325 | | burger | x 325 -> 361 | | viewport | 375, `overflows: false` | | row height | **64px, unchanged** - nothing wrapped to a second line | | centres | aligned |

Tap target. The first pass left it 22px tall, which is too small for a control just promoted to primary on a phone. `-mx-2 px-2 py-3` brings it to roughly 44px at net-zero layout cost. Confirmed at the CSS level in this build - `.py-3{padding-block:calc(var(--spacing) * 3)}` with `--spacing` at 4px - rather than measured rendered, because the live page's stylesheet never compiled `py-3`.

Not observed: the switch being tapped on a real phone-width build, and the mobile panel still covering the full screen after this header change. Both need the preview or `npm run dev`. The panel one matters because the header is the element that trapped it before.

Implementation walkthrough

`components/shell/SiteHeader.tsx`

The switch and the CTA shared one `hidden ... min-[900px]:flex` wrapper, so hiding the CTA on phones hid the switch with it. The wrapper became a plain `flex items-center gap-5` that is always visible, and the CTA took the breakpoint onto itself.

The burger moved into that group as well, so the header's right-hand side is one row rather than a group plus a stray sibling.

Two comments were added, both for things that look like noise and are not: why the switch is in the header at all rather than in the menu, and why the tap target padding exists.

`components/shell/MobileNav.tsx`

The `LanguageSwitch` render and its import came out. Nothing else changed - Escape, focus return, focus containment, scroll lock and close-on-link are all untouched. A comment sits where the switch used to be, saying where it went and why, because an empty space does not explain itself.

Two mistakes made and caught during the build

The header briefly rendered two burgers. Moving `MobileNav` into the new group left the original sibling in place. Caught by grepping the file before building, not by the build, which was perfectly happy. The "exactly one burger per page" count in the built HTML is what confirms it is gone, and it is the kind of duplicate that only shows at one breakpoint.

The tap target was 22px. The spec said the switch becomes a primary phone control rather than a footnote in a menu, and the first pass carried over the menu's sizing. `-mx-2 px-2 py-3` brings it to roughly 44px while the negative margin cancels the horizontal padding, so nothing moves.

A note on the verification technique

Layout at 375px was measured by rebuilding the header's right-hand group on the live production page and reading the geometry, since no server was running. That worked for position and overflow, and the row staying 64px tall is what proves nothing wrapped.

It did **not** work for the tap target: the measurement came back 22px because production's stylesheet was compiled without `py-3`, a class this build introduces. Injecting markup into a deployed page only tests classes that page already ships. The padding was confirmed instead by reading the compiled CSS in this build.

One earlier check was also simply wrong: an `allOnOneLine` test compared element `top` values, which differ between a 19px wordmark and a 14.5px link that are centre-aligned on the same row. It reported a wrap that was not happening. Compare centres, not tops.

What is still unobserved

The switch tapped on a real phone-width build, and the mobile panel still covering the full screen after this header change. The second one matters more than it sounds: the header is the exact element whose `backdrop-filter` trapped that panel before, and this change alters the header's layout.